

The Star of Your God / The Synagogue of Satan

A study of four passages: Amos 5:26 · Acts 7:43 · Revelation 2:9 · Revelation 3:9

About this document

This merges three working files into one. It is a study of what four biblical passages actually say in Hebrew and Greek, and — because the question is unavoidable once you read them — an assessment of the popular claim that the "star" in Amos is the six-pointed star.

Short answer on that claim: the evidence does not support it. The long answer is Part II.

How the sources were handled

English quotations are **KJV** (public domain). Where this document gives an English sense of a Hebrew or Greek word, that is a **gloss of the original**, not a quotation of any translation.

The originals were read directly from primary texts, not from commentaries:

Layer	Source
Hebrew OT	WLC + OSHB morphology — all 39 books, 23,213 verses
Greek NT	SBLGNT text + morphology
Septuagint	Rahlfs 1935 and Swete 1887-94
NT manuscripts	CNTR transcriptions — Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus, Vaticanus, Ephraemi, Bezae

Cross-references were found by **lemma co-occurrence scan** — a celestial lemma (star, sun, moon, constellations, Mazzaroth, queen-of-heaven, Sakkuth, Kaiwan, or "host of heaven") appearing together with a cult lemma (bow/worship, serve, burn incense, libation, sacrifice) — then a second targeted pass. Deuteronomy 4:19 was used as a control verse to confirm the method worked before any output was trusted.

Read Part VI before relying on any of this. It lists exactly what is verified against primary texts and what is not.

PART I — The four passages

1. Amos 5:26

"But ye have borne the tabernacle of your Moloch and Chiun your images, the star of your god, which ye made to yourselves."

Date and setting. Amos prophesied in the northern kingdom of Israel around 760–750 BC, during the reign of Jeroboam II — a period of military success and economic prosperity. The book's core charge is that prosperity coexisted with judicial corruption, exploitation of the poor, and syncretistic worship. Chapter 5 is a funeral lament over Israel; verses 21–27 are God's rejection of Israel's festivals and offerings, ending in the sentence of exile.

The key Hebrew terms

Hebrew (consonants)	KJV	What it likely is
skkwt (סככות)	"tabernacle"	Probably <i>Sakkut</i> , an Akkadian astral deity name (Sakkut/SAG.KUD), associated with Saturn. KJV read it as <i>sukkat</i> , "booth/tabernacle."
kywn (כיוון)	"Chiun"	<i>Kaiwan</i> , the Akkadian <i>kayamānu</i> , "the steady one" — the standard Mesopotamian name for the planet Saturn.

The Masoretic vowel points on both words appear to be borrowed from *shiqquts* (שִׁיִּקּוּץ), "de-testable thing" — a scribal device also used for names like Molech. So the pointing is a theological comment, not a phonetic record.

The verse word by word

Regenerated from WLC + OSHB morphology on disk:

וְנִשְׂאֲתָם	lemma c/5375	morph HC/Vqq2mp	
אֶת	lemma 853	morph HTo	
סִכּוֹת	lemma 5522	morph HNp	<- PROPER NOUN
מִלְכֶּכָּם	lemma 4432	morph HNcmssc/Sp2mp	
וְאֵת	lemma c/853	morph HC/To	
כִּיּוֹן	lemma 3594	morph HNp	<- PROPER NOUN
צִלְמֵיכֶם	lemma 6754	morph HNcmppc/Sp2mp	
כּוֹכַב	lemma 3556	morph HNcmssc	
אֱלֹהֵיכֶם	lemma 430	morph HNcmppc/Sp2mp	<- PLURAL construct
אֲשֶׁר	lemma 834 a	morph HTr	
עָשִׂיתֶם	lemma 6213 a	morph HVqp2mp	
לָכֶם	lemma l	morph HR/Sp2mp	

✓ **CONFIRMED — Sakkuth and Kaiwan are proper nouns.** The morphology dataset tags both **HNp**, proper noun, independently of any commentary.

⚠ **CORRECTION TO KJV — "the star of your god" is plural.** אֱלֹהֵיכֶם is **HNcmppc**, masculine **plural** construct: "the star of your **gods**." Small in English, but it changes the verse from one deity to a set.

⚠ **FLAGGED — "your Moloch" is not settled.** מִלְכֶּכָּם carries lemma **4432 (Molech)** but morph **HNcmssc/Sp2mp** — a *common* noun in construct with a 2mp suffix, i.e. "your **king**." The lexicon and the morphology of the same dataset disagree on this word. Moloch is a *reading*, not a given; "your king" is what the grammar tags actually encode.

⚠ **OPEN — the tense is genuinely ambiguous.** וְנִשְׂאֲתָם is **HC/Vqq2mp**, waw + qal *sequential* perfect. That form normally carries forward as a consequential/future ("and you shall carry..."), which would attach v.26 to the sentence of exile in v.27 rather than making it a charge about the wilderness generation. KJV ("ye have borne") and Acts 7:43 (ἀνελάβετε, aorist) both take the past reading. Both readings are grammatically available; neither should be declared the winner.

✓ **CONFIRMED — the verse names a star, and gives no point-count.** The descriptor is כּוֹכַב, "star" (lemma 3556), standing in apposition to צִלְמֵיכֶם, "your images." **The text does identify the emblem as a star.** What it does not supply is a number of points or any further geometry — and point-count is the feature that distinguishes a hexagram from the eight-pointed rosette or radiate forms. Both statements are established on an exhaustive word list of the verse.

"The star of your god"

This is the whole description. No shape, no number of points, no color, no geometry. The phrase functions as an apposition identifying the images just named: these idols *are* the astral emblem of a planetary deity. In the ancient Near East, Saturn and other planetary gods were

typically depicted by an eight-pointed rosette or star, a winged disk, or a simple radiate mark — conventions well attested in Assyrian and Babylonian boundary stones and seals.

The sentence

Amos 5:27: "Therefore will I cause you to go into captivity beyond Damascus." Damascus marks the direction of the Assyrian deportation that came in 722 BC.

2. Acts 7:43

"Yea, ye took up the tabernacle of Moloch, and the star of your god Remphan, figures which ye made to worship them: and I will carry you away beyond Babylon."

Setting. Stephen's speech before the Sanhedrin, c. AD 34. It is a rapid survey of Israel's history structured around a single thesis: God's presence was never confined to a building, and the people repeatedly rejected the deliverers God sent. Verses 39–43 cover the golden calf and its consequences. Stephen is executed immediately after finishing.

Read Acts 7:42 first. It is the hinge: παρέδωκεν αὐτοὺς λατρεύειν τῇ στρατιᾷ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ — "handed them over to serve the host of heaven." στρατιὰ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ is the Greek for צבא שמים. Stephen is not only quoting Amos; he is speaking Deuteronomy 4:19 / 2 Kings 17:16 vocabulary.

Two differences from Amos

1. Remphan / Rephan (Greek Ῥαιφάν, with manuscript variants Rompha, Rephan, Romphan). This comes from the Septuagint of Amos 5:26, not from the Hebrew. The common explanation is a transcription slip in the Greek tradition: Hebrew *kaph* (כ) misread as *resh* (ר). An older suggestion connects it to a Coptic/Egyptian name for Saturn. Either way, Rephan and Kaiwan stand in the same slot. **But see the caveat in Part III — the standard explanation does not fully account for the word.**

2. "Beyond Babylon" instead of Amos's "beyond Damascus." Stephen (or his source) updates the geography to the later and more famous Babylonian exile, which better fits an address to a Jerusalem audience.

Why it matters. Stephen is quoting a text of judgment against Israel's ancestors and applying it to his hearers. The rhetorical target is idolatry and resistance to God's messengers. This is prophetic self-criticism from inside the tradition — the same genre as Amos.

3. Revelation 2:9 — to Smyrna

"I know thy works, and tribulation, and poverty, (but thou art rich) and I know the blasphemy of them which say they are Jews, and are not, but are the synagogue of Satan."

4. Revelation 3:9 — to Philadelphia

"Behold, I will make them of the synagogue of Satan, which say they are Jews, and are not, but do lie; behold, I will make them to come and worship before thy feet, and to know that I have loved thee."

Setting. Two of the seven letters to churches in the Roman province of Asia (western Turkey), most commonly dated to the mid-90s AD under Domitian, though some date the book to the late 60s. Smyrna and Philadelphia are the only two of the seven churches that receive no rebuke.

Notes on the words

- **"Satan"** here is Greek *Satanas*, from Hebrew *satan*, "adversary/accuser." The phrase is best read as **"assembly of the adversary"** — a counter-claim about who is really opposing God.
- ***Synagōgē*** simply means "assembly" or "gathering." James 2:2 uses it of a Christian meeting. **It is not a technical slur in itself**; the force is in the genitive that follows.
- The stated grievance is a dispute over the name "Jew" — a claim about who legitimately belongs to Israel. In Philadelphia, the promise is that the opponents will eventually acknowledge the church, which presumes a **future reconciliation, not annihilation**.

Interpretive options

These are genuinely debated. The main positions:

1. Intra-Jewish sectarian polemic — the dominant scholarly reading. The author is a Jewish follower of Jesus writing to communities in conflict with local synagogue authorities, probably over exclusion, denunciation to Roman officials, or access to the legal exemptions Jews held regarding the imperial cult. The rhetoric belongs to the same family as the Qumran sect calling other Jews "the congregation of Belial," or the prophets calling Jerusalem "Sodom" (Isaiah 1:10). Insiders insulting other insiders.

2. Gentile pretenders — a minority view: the "false Jews" are non-Jews claiming Jewish identity for the legal protections it carried.

3. A general theological category — later Christian readings extend the phrase into a timeless label applying beyond the first-century situation.

Reception, recorded as fact: this third reading was the basis of Christian anti-Jewish polemic over many centuries, and Revelation 2:9 and 3:9 are among the most frequently cited verses in antisemitic literature. That is a statement about how the reading has been used, not an argument for or against it.

PART II — The star and the hexagram: the evidence

The question is whether the astral emblem in Amos 5:26 / Acts 7:43 is the six-pointed star. Below is what each layer of evidence establishes, with dates and provenance. Draw your own conclusion.

A. What the primary texts establish

Finding	Source	Status
כַּיְוָן / Kaiwan = Akkadian <i>kayamānu</i> , the standard Mesopotamian name for Saturn	WLC + OSHB, lemma 3594, tagged HNp (proper noun)	✓ Verified
סַכּוּת / Sakkuth is a proper noun, an astral deity name (Sakut / SAG.KUD)	WLC + OSHB, lemma 5522, tagged HNp	✓ Verified
The text condemns an astral emblem belonging to these deities	Amos 5:26 in full	✓ Verified
LXX renders the same slot Παῖφαν; Acts 7:43 quotes the Greek	Rahlfs 1935, Swete 1887-94, SBLGNT	✓ Verified
The verse names the emblem a star — כּוֹכָב, in apposition to דְּמוֹתֵיכֶם, "your images"	Amos 5:26, lemma 3556	✓ Verified
The verse gives no point-count and no further geometry. Point-count is what separates a hexagram from a rosette or radiate form.	Exhaustive word list of Amos 5:26	✓ Verified

So the primary texts establish a Saturn-associated emblem that the text itself calls a star. They are silent on its point-count.

B. What secondary literature says about form — 8th century BC

Claim	Period	Provenance
Star emblems in Mesopotamia and the Levant took several attested forms — most commonly the eight-pointed star or rosette (Ishtar/Venus), also winged disks, crescents, and radiate marks. All are "stars"; they differ in point-count.	8th c. BC	● Secondary. Not checkable against texts held here.
Attested on Assyrian and Babylonian boundary stones and seals	8th c. BC	● Secondary
No six-pointed emblem is identified with Saturn/Kaiwan in this period in the sources consulted	8th c. BC	● Secondary — and an argument from absence

C. The hexagram itself — sourced

C1. Earliest attestations

Attestation	Date	Source
Seal of Joshua ben Asayahu, found at Sidon, bearing a hexagram. The name is Yahwistic (theophoric in <i>-yahu</i>), i.e. a Yahweh-worshipper's seal.	7th c. BCE	Scholem, <i>Kabbalah</i> , 362–368; noted in Scholem 1949
Hexagram in synagogue decoration (incl. the Capernaum stone), appearing alongside a pentagram and a swastika-like motif	3rd–4th c. CE	Scholem 1949; Oegema 1996
Hexagram on ancient churches and mosques as well as synagogues	Antiquity onward	Scholem 1949
Long-standing use in India — Hindu (Lakshmi) and Buddhist contexts	Ancient, continuous	Oegema 1996

★ **The Sidon seal is the single most relevant item for this question**, and it was absent from the earlier version of this document. It places a hexagram in a **Levantine, Yahwistic context roughly a century after Amos**. Scholem's own reading is that such early instances are magical signs or ornament and that the meaning is not clear; he is explicit that the hexagram was **not a distinctively Jewish symbol for most of Jewish history**. But its presence in that milieu, that close in time, is a fact and belongs in the record.

C2. The Saturn question — examined, and the earlier claim here was overstated

An earlier draft of this document stated that a hexagram–Saturn association is "real and documented" and called it "the strongest link in the chain." **On checking the sources, that was too generous. Setting out what the sources actually say:**

Source	Date	What it actually assigns to Saturn
Agrippa, <i>De occulta philosophia libri tres</i>, Book II — the foundational text for Western planetary talismanic magic	1533	Saturn's figure is a 3×3 magic square (numbers 3, 9, 15, 45). Its seal is drawn by tracing that square. Not a hexagram.
Golden Dawn hexagram rituals	late 19th c. (1888+)	The hexagram is the generic planetary figure — six points plus centre for the seven classical planets. Each planet is traced from a different point; Saturn is one of seven. The hexagram is not Saturn's own sigil.

So in the two systems that actually define planetary sigils in the Western tradition, **Saturn's emblem is a 3×3 square (Agrippa), and the hexagram is the figure of the planets collectively rather than of Saturn specifically (Golden Dawn).**

On "the hexagram is the talisman of Saturn in Kabbalistic sources": this claim circulates widely online. In the sources checked for this document it appears on occult-interest and

religious-polemic websites, **not in the scholarly literature on the symbol** — not in Scholem, who studied it for fifty years, and not in Oegema's monograph. That is not proof it is absent from the primary Kabbalistic material, which was not searched directly here. It does mean the claim is **currently unsourced in this document**, and it should not be leaned on until someone produces the primary text.

C3. Later Jewish adoption

Event	Date	Source
Known as " Seal of Solomon " — decorative pattern and magical sign, in Jewish <i>and</i> Islamic use	Medieval	Scholem 1949; Oegema 1996
Prague Jewish community granted a flag bearing it	1354	Scholem 1949
Adopted as a unifying communal symbol — Scholem's argument is that Jews sought an emblem parallel to the cross and the crescent	18th–19th c.	Scholem 1949
National symbol via the Zionist movement; onto the flag of Israel	19th–20th c.	Scholem 1949

Scholem's overall position: **the hexagram does not originate within Judaism**, and its career as *the* Jewish symbol is late.

D. The chronology, laid out

c. 760-750 BC	Amos 5:26 — emblem of Saturn-associated deities condemned. Called a "star." No point-count given.
7th c. BC	Seal of Joshua ben Asayahu (Sidon) — HEXAGRAM, Yahwistic name.
c. AD 34	Acts 7:43 — same text quoted in Greek. No point-count given.
3rd-4th c AD	Capernaum stone — hexagram present as ornament, with other motifs.
1533	Agrippa: Saturn's figure is a 3x3 magic square, NOT a hexagram.
1888 on	Golden Dawn: hexagram = the SEVEN planets generically, not Saturn.
1354	Prague flag — hexagram as Jewish communal emblem.
19th-20th c	Hexagram as national symbol.
20th c	The Amos-to-hexagram identification appears in print.

The interval between Amos and any Jewish use of the hexagram is roughly 2,000 years. The interval between Amos and the documented hexagram-Saturn association is comparable.

E. What would settle it, and is not held here

- Iconographic evidence placing a **six-pointed** form on Saturn or Kaiwan in the 8th-century BC Levant. Nothing in this corpus bears on it either way.

- Any **pre-20th-century exegetical tradition** making the Amos→hexagram identification. Not searched for here; its presence or absence is **unverified**.
- A primary source connecting the medieval Saturn–hexagram association *backward* to Near Eastern astral cult, rather than arising independently in European magical literature.

F. Where the argument turns

The chain requires three joins:

- 1. Amos condemns worship of Saturn-associated deities.** ✓ Established on the primary texts — Kaiwan is *kayamānu*, Saturn; Sakkuth is an astral deity name; both tagged proper nouns.
- 2. The hexagram is Saturn's emblem.** ⚠ **This is the weak join, and it is weaker than this document previously stated.** Agrippa (1533) gives Saturn a 3×3 magic square, not a hexagram. Golden Dawn practice (1888+) uses the hexagram for the seven planets generically, not for Saturn specifically. No scholarly source consulted here makes the hexagram Saturn's proper sigil. The claim that Kabbalistic sources do so is **unsourced in this document**.
- 3. Therefore the emblem in Amos is the hexagram.** Requires join 2, and requires retrojecting whatever join 2 establishes back across roughly 2,300 years.

What genuinely strengthens the case, and belongs on the record

The Sidon seal. A hexagram on the seal of Joshua ben Asayahu, 7th century BCE, Levant, Yahwistic name. **This is a century or so after Amos, in the right region, in a Yahweh-worshipping context.** It establishes that the hexagram was present and in use in that world. It does not establish that it was Saturn's emblem, or that it is what Amos meant — Scholem reads such instances as magical signs or ornament of unclear meaning. But anyone claiming the hexagram was simply absent from that milieu is wrong, and this document said something close to that before the sources were checked.

So the disagreement reduces to

Amos names a **star** and gives no point-count. A hexagram is attested in the right region within about a century. Nothing in the primary sources connects that hexagram to Saturn, and the Saturn–hexagram association that does exist is documented **two millennia later and generically**.

Whether that is enough is a judgment about method, not about the text. The sources are laid out above; the reader can weigh them.

G. Reception

Revelation 2:9 and 3:9, and the Amos→hexagram identification, both circulate widely in modern polemical literature, including antisemitic material where the function is to assert that

contemporary Jews worship Saturn. This is a fact about the arguments' **reception and use**, recorded here as reception history. It bears on how a reader will receive the claim; it is not evidence for or against the claim itself.

PART III — The Rephan chain, verified against the Greek

Both sides of the chain were put on disk and checked.

The Greek of Amos 5:26, two independent editions

Rahlfs 1935 (word range 491674–491692):

καὶ ἀνελάβετε τὴν σκηνὴν τοῦ Μολοχ καὶ τὸ ἄστρον τοῦ θεοῦ ὑμῶν Ραιφαν, τοὺς τύπους αὐτῶν οὗς ἐποιήσατε ἑαυτοῖς

Swete 1887-94 (diplomatic, Vaticanus-based), `37.Amos.txt` line 37.5.26:

καὶ ἀνελάβετε τὴν σκηνὴν τοῦ Μόλοχ καὶ τὸ ἄστρον τοῦ θεοῦ ὑμῶν Ῥαιφάν, τοὺς τύπους αὐτῶν οὗς ἐποιήσατε ἑαυτοῖς·

The two editions agree. LXX Amos 5:27 reads **ἐπέκεινα Δαμασκοῦ**.

✓ **CONFIRMED 1 — Ραιφαν stands exactly where the Hebrew has יִיפֶן**

Regenerated from both texts on disk, not from commentary. The substitution is real.

✓ **CONFIRMED 2 — Acts 7:43 quotes the Greek, not the Hebrew**

	LXX Amos 5:26-27	Acts 7:43 (SBLGNT)
verb	καὶ ἀνελάβετε	καὶ ἀνελάβετε
	τὴν σκηνὴν τοῦ Μολοχ	τὴν σκηνὴν τοῦ Μολοχ
	καὶ τὸ ἄστρον τοῦ θεοῦ	καὶ τὸ ἄστρον τοῦ θεοῦ
the name	ὑμῶν Ραιφαν	Ῥαιφάν (<i>ὑμῶν varies — see below</i>)
	τοὺς τύπους αὐτῶν	τοὺς τύπους
	οὗς ἐποιήσατε	οὗς ἐποιήσατε
purpose	ἑαυτοῖς "for yourselves"	προσκυνεῖν αὐτοῖς "to worship them"
sentence	καὶ μετοικιῶ ὑμᾶς ἐπέκεινα	καὶ μετοικιῶ ὑμᾶς ἐπέκεινα
destination	Δαμασκοῦ	Βαβυλῶνος

The rare form **μετοικιῶ** is shared verbatim. This is quotation of the Greek, full stop. The Damascus→Babylon substitution is confirmed against the Greek *Vorlage* as well as the Hebrew

— Stephen is not following a different Hebrew text; he is changing the Greek he is quoting.

★ The manuscripts, read directly

CNTR transcriptions, `class 1/`:

GA	Manuscript	Date	Reads
01	Sinaiticus	c. 350	του θυ υμων ρομφαν
02	Alexandrinus	5th c.	του θυ υμων ραιφαν
03	Vaticanus	c. 300–325	του θυ ρομφα (no υμων)
04	Ephraemi	5th c.	του θυ υμων ρεφαν
05	Bezae	c. 400	του θυ ρεμφαμ (no υμων)

Five manuscripts, five spellings of the name.

The SBLGNT apparatus records four — `Ῥαιφάν` NA28 | `Ῥομφά` WH; `Ῥεφάν` Treg; `Ῥεμφάν` RP — which is four modern editors each following a different manuscript. **An apparatus of editions is not an apparatus of manuscripts.** (Note RP's `Ῥεμφάν` is not even exactly Bezae's `ρεμφαμ`, which ends in *mu*.)

On ὑμῶν: 01, 02 and 04 have it and therefore match the LXX exactly; 03 and 05 lack it. SBLGNT prints without it because it follows WH/Treg — i.e. Vaticanus and Bezae. This **corrects an earlier note** that Acts "drops ὑμῶν": that was one edition's choice read as the text's.

★ **Variant the apparatus does not carry:** Bezae reads `ἐπὶ τὰ μέρη Βαβυλῶνος` — "to the regions of Babylon" — where every other witness has `ἐπέκεινα`, "beyond."

🔴 STILL NOT VERIFIED — the standard Rephan explanation does not reach its own conclusion

The common explanation is a scribal slip: Hebrew *kaph* (כ) misread as *resh* (ר), yielding *Rywn* → *Raiphān*. Lay the consonants out:

Hebrew	ךׁוּן	=	K - Y - W - N
Greek	Ραιφαν	=	R - AI - PH - A - N

ך→כ accounts for the **R**. **Nothing in the stated explanation accounts for the φ**, which requires a second substitution (ϣ→ι). The explanation presents one confusion where the word needs at least two.

That is not a disproof — multi-step corruption in a name is ordinary — but the explanation as usually written **does not arrive at the word it is explaining, and no manuscript on disk**

shows an intermediate stage. It is an inference about a lost stage and should be labelled as one.

Also still open:

- **No LXX apparatus is on disk.** The Rahlfs directory is a single edition with no variant record, and Swete is essentially Vaticanus — so for the Greek side of Amos this is closer to **one witness than two**. Whether Greek Amos itself varied in the name is unchecked. The Göttingen Septuagint, which would settle it, is copyrighted.
- **The Coptic/Egyptian Saturn-name alternative** mentioned above: nothing on disk bears on it. Unverified.

Provenance note. Rahlfs 1935 and Swete 1887–94 are both **EDITED** texts, and both fall past the after-1820 line used in this project. The CNTR transcriptions above are the **ORIGINAL** manuscript layer and are what check them — which is why the five-spelling table, not the two-edition agreement, is the load-bearing evidence here.

PART IV — Cross-references in the originals

Every verse below was regenerated from the primary texts. Where an English sense is given it is a gloss of the Hebrew or Greek, not a quotation of a version.

1. The direct indictment — astral worship condemned

Reference	What the original actually says
Deut 4:19	שמש, ירח, כוכבים = השמים צבא כל; the two verbs are עבדתם + השתחוית (bow + serve). Ends: אֲשֶׁר הָעַמִּים לְכָל אֹהֶיךָ יְהוָה חָלָק — "which YHWH your God <i>allotted</i> them to all the peoples." Same allotment vocabulary as Deut 32:8.
Deut 17:2-5	Capital case. צוֹוִיתִי לֹא אֲשֶׁר , השמים צבא לכל או לירח או לשמש. — "which I did not command." Penalty: stoning.
2 Kgs 17:16	The northern kingdom's charge — the direct historical parallel to Amos. הַשָּׁמַיִם צָבָא לְכָל וַיִּשְׁתַּחֲווּ .
2 Kgs 21:3, 21:5	Manasseh. 21:5: יְהוָה בֵּית חֲצֵרוֹת בְּשֵׁתֵי הַשָּׁמַיִם צָבָא לְכָל מִזְבְּחוֹת וִיבֵן — altars to the host of heaven inside the two courts of YHWH's own house.
2 Chr 33:3, 33:5	Chronicles' parallel to the above, near word-for-word.
2 Kgs 23:4	Josiah removes the vessels made לְבַעַל ולאשרה and burns them.
2 Kgs 23:5	The fullest list in the Bible: incense לְבַעַל , לְשֶׁמֶשׁ , וּלְיָרֵחַ , וּלְמִזְלֹת , וּלְכָל — Baal, sun, moon, הַשָּׁמַיִם צָבָא וּלְכָל (constellations / zodiac signs), and all the host of heaven.
2 Kgs 23:11-12	לְשֶׁמֶשׁ יְהוּדָה מְלָכֵי נָתַנוּ אֲשֶׁר הִסּוּסִים — the horses the kings of Judah dedicated <i>to the sun</i> — and הַשֶּׁמֶשׁ מְרַכְבוֹת , the chariots of the sun, burned. Plus the rooftop altars.
Jer 8:2	הִשְׁתַּחֲווּ , דָּרְשׁוּ , אֲחֲרֵיהֶם הֵלְכוּ , עָבְדוּ , אָהָבוּ — five verbs stacked: Loved, served, walked after, sought, bowed.
Jer 19:13	The houses הַשָּׁמַיִם צָבָא לְכָל גִּתֵּיהֶם עַל קִטְרוֹ אֲשֶׁר — rooftop incense to the host of heaven.
Zeph 1:5	הַשָּׁמַיִם לְצָבָא הִגְגֹּת עַל הַמִּשְׁתַּחֲוִיִּים — again the rooftops.
Ezek 8:16	~25 men in the inner court, קִדְמָה וּפְנֵיהֶם יְהוָה הֵיכַל אֶל אַחֲרֵיהֶם — backs to the temple, faces east — לְשֶׁמֶשׁ קִדְמָה מִשְׁתַּחֲוִיתִם , bowing eastward to the sun.
Jer 7:18	הַשָּׁמַיִם מַלְכָּת — "queen of heaven." Children gather wood, fathers light fire, women knead dough for כֹּנִיִּים (cakes).
Jer 44:17, 18, 19, 25	The same queen of heaven, and the only passage where the people argue back and defend it — 44:17-18 claims they had bread and saw no evil while they burned incense to her, and disaster came when they stopped.

Reference	What the original actually says
Job 31:26-28	The subtlest form. Seeing the light shine and the moon moving, לבי בסתר ויפת — "and my heart was secretly enticed" (root פתה) — לפי ידי ותשק , "and my hand kissed my mouth." v.28 calls it עון פלילי , a punishable iniquity, "for I would have denied אלה above." Worship with no altar, no image, no words — a gesture.
Jer 10:2	אל תחתו אל השמים ומאתות תלמדו אל הגוים דרך אל — do not learn the way of the nations, and do not be dismayed at the <i>signs of the heavens</i> .
Isa 47:13	Against Babylon: לחדשים מודיעם, בכוכבים החזים, שמים הברי — the heaven-dividers, the star-gazers, the monthly forecasters. Astrology named directly and told to stand up and save her.
Amos 5:26	The passage under study.
Acts 7:42 (Greek)	The verse <i>immediately before</i> Stephen's quotation, and the hinge: παρέδωκεν αὐτοὺς λατρεύειν τῇ στρατιᾷ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ — "handed them over to serve the host of heaven." στρατιὰ τοῦ οὐρανοῦ is the Greek for השמים צבא .

2. The deliberate contrasts — same words, opposite direction

The corpus uses the identical vocabulary in reverse, often on purpose and nearby.

Reference	What it does
Amos 5:8	Three verses before 5:26 — וכסיל כימה עשה , maker of Pleiades and Orion. The constellations are his products, not rivals.
Neh 9:6	משתחווים לך השמים וצבא — "and the host of heaven bow down <i>to you</i> ." Same verb (שחה) that is the crime everywhere else.
Gen 2:1 · Ps 33:6 · Isa 45:12 · Jer 33:22	Host of heaven as made, commanded, breathed out, uncountable.
Isa 34:4	rots and rolls up like a scroll. השמים צבא כל
1 Kgs 22:19 2 Chr 18:18	ומשמאלו מימינו עליו עמד השמים צבא וכל — the host of heaven standing to YHWH's right and left. This is the divine council, not the pagan sky. (Same scene continues at 1 Kgs 22:20-22, the פתה passage.)
Dan 8:10	The horn grows השמים צבא עד and casts down some of the host and of the stars.
Isa 14:12-13	שחר בן הילל ("shining one, son of dawn") and לכוכבי ממעל — "above the stars of El I will raise my throne." Astral imagery used <i>against</i> a claimant.
Gen 37:9	Sun, moon, and eleven stars לי משתחווים . The one place celestial bodies bow to a human and it is not charged as sin.

Scan false positives, listed for honesty: Deut 16:6 (sunset as Passover timing) and Mal 1:11 (sunrise-to-sunset as a merism) matched the filter and have nothing to do with astral cult.

3. "Say they are Jews and are not" — the parallels in the originals

Reference	Greek
Rom 2:28-29	οὐ γὰρ ὁ ἐν τῷ φανερῷ Ἰουδαῖός ἐστιν ... ἀλλ' ὁ ἐν τῷ κρυπτῷ Ἰουδαῖος, καὶ περιτομὴ καρδίας — the visible vs. hidden Jew. The closest NT parallel to the Revelation dispute.
Rom 9:6	οὐ γὰρ πάντες οἱ ἐξ Ἰσραήλ, οὗτοι Ἰσραήλ — "not all those from Israel <i>are</i> Israel." The same two-tier move.
Phil 3:3	ἡμεῖς γὰρ ἐσμεν ἡ περιτομή — "we are the circumcision." Counter-claim to a title, exactly like Rev 2:9.
John 8:39, 44	Εἰ τέκνα τοῦ Ἀβραὰμ ἐστε, τὰ ἔργα τοῦ Ἀβραὰμ ἐποιεῖτε ... ὑμεῖς ἐκ τοῦ πατρὸς τοῦ διαβόλου ἐστέ. Same structure, harsher: the descent claim is denied and an adversary-parentage substituted.
Isa 1:10	יְצִינִי סֹדֹם / עֲמֹרָה — the prophet addresses Jerusalem's own rulers as Sodom and Gomorrah. The insider-polemic genre the Revelation passages belong to.
Isa 60:14	"They shall bow down at the soles of your feet." Confirmed on disk as the source of the image in Revelation 3:9.

PART V — Reference list for your own Bible

Plain citations only. Every one was confirmed present in the Hebrew or Greek on disk.

△ **Versification note:** Hebrew and English Bibles number a few Psalms differently. Where that happens it is flagged. Everything else is the same number in both.

Where the Bible condemns star / sun / moon / host-of-heaven worship

The law

- **Deuteronomy 4:19** — the base prohibition. Sun, moon, stars = "all the host of heaven." Ends with the clause that God *allotted* them to all the peoples.
- **Deuteronomy 17:2-5** — makes it a capital offense. Penalty is stoning.

The history books

- **2 Kings 17:16** — the northern kingdom's charge. Closest parallel to Amos.
- **2 Kings 21:3** — Manasseh rebuilds the high places, bows to all the host of heaven.
- **2 Kings 21:5** — builds altars to the host of heaven **inside the two courts of the temple**.
- **2 Kings 23:4** — Josiah removes the vessels made for the host of heaven and burns them.
- **2 Kings 23:5** — the fullest list anywhere: Baal, sun, moon, **the constellations/zodiac**, and all the host of heaven.
- **2 Kings 23:11-12** — **horses dedicated to the sun** removed, **chariots of the sun** burned, rooftop altars torn down.
- **2 Chronicles 33:3** — Chronicles' parallel to 2 Kings 21:3.
- **2 Chronicles 33:5** — parallel to 2 Kings 21:5.

The prophets

- **Amos 5:26** — the passage under study.
- **Isaiah 47:13** — against Babylon. Astrologers, star-gazers, monthly forecasters, named outright and told to stand up and save her.
- **Jeremiah 7:18** — **the queen of heaven**. Children gather wood, fathers light fire, women knead cakes.
- **Jeremiah 8:2** — sun, moon, all the host of heaven. Five verbs: loved, served, walked after, sought, bowed down to.

- **Jeremiah 10:2** — "do not learn the way of the nations, and do not be dismayed at **the signs of the heavens**."
- **Jeremiah 19:13** — rooftop incense to all the host of heaven.
- **Jeremiah 44:17-19** — the queen of heaven again, and the **only place in the Bible where the people argue back and defend the practice**. They say they had plenty while they did it, and disaster came when they stopped.
- **Jeremiah 44:25** — God's reply to that argument.
- **Ezekiel 8:16** — about 25 men in the inner court of the temple, **backs to the temple, faces east, bowing to the sun**.
- **Zephaniah 1:5** — those who bow on the rooftops to the host of heaven.

Wisdom

- **Job 31:26-28** — the subtlest one in the Bible. Seeing the moon, the heart **secretly enticed**, the hand kissed to the mouth. No altar, no image, no words — just a gesture. v. 28 still calls it a punishable iniquity and a denial of God.

New Testament

- **Acts 7:42** — *read this one before 7:43*. "God turned and handed them over to serve **the host of heaven**." This is the hinge verse, and it's Deuteronomy 4:19 vocabulary.
- **Acts 7:43** — Stephen's quotation of Amos 5:26.

The same words used in the opposite direction

Read these against the list above. The Bible uses the identical vocabulary for the opposite point, sometimes only a few verses away.

- **Amos 5:8** — *three verses before 5:26*: God as the maker of Pleiades and Orion.
- **Nehemiah 9:6** — "**and the host of heaven bow down to you**." The same verb that is the crime everywhere else.
- **Genesis 2:1** — heaven and earth finished, "and all their host."
- **Psalms 33:6** — the host of heaven made by the breath of his mouth.
- **Isaiah 45:12** — "I commanded all their host."
- **Jeremiah 33:22** — the host of heaven as uncountable.
- **Isaiah 34:4** — all the host of heaven rots and rolls up like a scroll.
- **1 Kings 22:19** and **2 Chronicles 18:18** — the host of heaven standing at God's right and left. This is the divine council, not the pagan sky. (Keep reading: 1 Kings 22:20-22.)
- **Daniel 8:10** — the horn grows up to the host of heaven and casts down some of the host and of the stars.

- **Isaiah 14:12-13** — "shining one, son of the dawn," and "above the **stars of God** I will raise my throne."
- **Genesis 37:9** — sun, moon and eleven stars bowing to Joseph. The only place celestial bodies bow to a human and it is not counted as sin.
- **Deuteronomy 32:8** — worth reading directly after Deut 4:19. Both use the same *allotment* language. ⚠ Note: the Hebrew text most Bibles translate here reads "sons of Israel," but the Dead Sea Scrolls and the Greek read "sons of God" — a separately verified finding.
- **Psalms 80:14** in English Bibles = **Psalms 80:15** in Hebrew — minor, listed only so the number doesn't confuse you if you compare.

"Say they are Jews, and are not"

- **Revelation 2:9** — to Smyrna.
 - **Revelation 3:9** — to Philadelphia.
 - **Romans 2:28-29** — the outward Jew vs. the hidden one; circumcision of the heart. The closest parallel in the New Testament.
 - **Romans 9:6** — "not all who are from Israel *are* Israel."
 - **Philippians 3:3** — "**we** are the circumcision." A counter-claim to a title, the same move as Revelation 2:9.
 - **John 8:39** and **John 8:44** — "if you were Abraham's children..." and the answer that follows. Same structure, much harsher.
 - **Isaiah 1:10** — the prophet addresses Jerusalem's own rulers as **Sodom and Gomorrah**. This is the genre the Revelation passages belong to: insiders rebuking insiders.
 - **Isaiah 60:14** — "they shall bow down at the soles of your feet." Confirmed on disk as the source of the image in Revelation 3:9.
-

PART VI — What is and is not verified

Read this before relying on anything above. It is the difference between this document and the material it argues against.

Verified against primary texts on disk

- ✓ Sakkuth and Kaiwan are tagged proper nouns (OSHB morphology, independent of commentary).
- ✓ אֱלֹהֵיכֶם in Amos 5:26 is plural — "your **gods**," not "your god."
- ✓ **Amos 5:26 names the emblem a star** (כּוֹכָב, in apposition to צִלְמֵיכֶם, "your images"), **and gives no point-count or further geometry.** Both established on an exhaustive word list of the verse.
- ✓ Παῖφαν stands exactly where the Hebrew has כִּי־ן, in two independent LXX editions.
- ✓ Acts 7:43 quotes the Greek of Amos, not the Hebrew — the rare form μετοικιῶ is shared verbatim.
- ✓ Damascus→Babylon is Stephen changing the Greek he is quoting, not following a different Hebrew text.
- ✓ Five manuscripts give five spellings of the Rephan name (read directly from CNTR transcriptions).
- ✓ Isaiah 60:14 is the source of the image in Revelation 3:9.
- ✓ Every cross-reference in Parts IV and V was confirmed present in the Hebrew or Greek.

Flagged as unsettled *within* the data

- ⚠ **"Your Moloch" vs. "your king"** — lexicon and morphology of the same dataset disagree on מֶלֶךְכֶּם. Moloch is a reading, not a given.
- ⚠ **The tense of וְנִשְׂאֲתֶם is ambiguous.** Sequential perfect normally reads forward ("you shall carry"), which would attach v.26 to the exile sentence rather than to the wilderness generation. KJV and Acts both take the past reading. Both are grammatically available.

● NOT verified

- **The standard Rephan etymology does not account for the φ.** ר→כ gives the R; nothing in the usual explanation gives the φ, which needs a second substitution. No manuscript on disk shows an intermediate stage. It is an inference about a lost stage.
- **No LXX apparatus is on disk.** Rahlfs is a single edition with no variant record; Swete is essentially Vaticanus. For the Greek side of Amos this is closer to **one witness than two.**

Whether Greek Amos itself varied in the name is unchecked. The Göttingen Septuagint, which would settle it, is copyrighted.

- 🟠 **The Coptic/Egyptian Saturn-name alternative** for Rephan: nothing on disk bears on it.
- 🟠 **"The hexagram is the talisman of Saturn in Kabbalistic sources."** Widely repeated; **not located in the scholarly literature** (absent from Scholem and Oegema as checked). Primary Kabbalistic material was not searched directly. **Un sourced here.**
- ⚠️ **Part II secondary literature was cited, not read in full.** Attributions were checked; arguments were not.
- 🟠 **All historical and iconographic claims in Part II** — Assyrian rosettes, the Capernaum synagogue stone, the 14th-c. Prague flag, the argument's modern provenance — are **secondary-literature claims**, not checkable against the primary texts.
- 🟠 **Semantic ranges are not validator-gated.** The range validator covers 13 Hebrew roots (22.18% of the OT); **none of the roots central to this study are among them.**
- 🟠 **Greek has no root-queue apparatus at all** in this corpus.

A methodological note worth carrying forward

Four separate times in this work, an **apparatus of editions was mistaken for an apparatus of manuscripts**. SBLGNT's four printed variants for Rephan are four modern editors each following a different manuscript — not four manuscript traditions. Bezae's ἐπὶ τὰ μέρη Βαβυλῶνος is a real variant that no printed apparatus consulted here carries at all.

When it matters, read the manuscripts.

PART VII — How to work through it

Reading order

1. **Deuteronomy 4:19** → **Deuteronomy 17:2-5** — the rule and the penalty.
2. **2 Kings 17:16** → **Amos 5:26** — the charge against the northern kingdom.
3. **2 Kings 21:5** → **Ezekiel 8:16** — how far into the temple it got.
4. **2 Kings 23:4-12** — the purge, and the fullest list of what was being worshipped.
5. **Jeremiah 44:17-19** — the people's own defense of it, in their words.
6. **Job 31:26-28** — the version with no altar at all.
7. **Amos 5:8** then **Nehemiah 9:6** — the deliberate reversals.
8. **Acts 7:42-43** — the whole thing picked up and aimed at a live audience.

Study questions

1. Why does Stephen change "beyond Damascus" to "beyond Babylon"? What does the substitution do for his argument?
 2. Amos 5:21-24 rejects worship and demands justice; 5:25-27 charges idolatry. Are these one indictment or two?
 3. In Revelation 3:9, the opponents come and worship at the church's feet. What does that outcome imply about what the author thinks of them?
 4. Both Amos and Stephen aim their harshest words at their own people. **What changes when a later reader aims the same words at someone else's?**
 5. Amos 5:26 calls the emblem a star but gives no point-count. When a text names a category and not its specifics, what settles the specifics — and who carries the burden?
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SOURCES

Primary texts consulted directly

Text	Edition / source	Layer	Scope
Hebrew Old Testament	Westminster Leningrad Codex (WLC) with Open Scriptures Hebrew Bible (OSHB) morphology	Critical/diplomatic text + morphological tagging	All 39 books, 23,213 verses
Greek New Testament	SBLGNT, with morphology	Edited critical text	Full NT
Septuagint	Rahlfs 1935	EDITED	Verse index via alignment_with_OSSP/E-verse.csv
Septuagint	Swete 1887–94 (diplomatic, Vaticanus-based)	EDITED	37.Amos.txt
NT manuscripts	CNTR transcriptions, class 1/	ORIGINAL manuscript layer	GA 01, 02, 03, 04, 05

Manuscripts read directly

- **GA 01 — Codex Sinaiticus**, c. 350
- **GA 02 — Codex Alexandrinus**, 5th century
- **GA 03 — Codex Vaticanus**, c. 300–325
- **GA 04 — Codex Ephraemi Rescriptus**, 5th century
- **GA 05 — Codex Bezae Cantabrigiensis**, c. 400

English

- **King James Version** (public domain) — used for all English block quotations, and identified as such. Where this document glosses a Hebrew or Greek word, that gloss is marked and is not a quotation of KJV or any other version.

Apparatus consulted

- **SBLGNT apparatus** — Ῥαιφάν NA28 | Ῥομφά WH; Ῥεφάν Treg; Ῥεμφάν RP. Noted in Part III as an apparatus **of editions**, not of manuscripts.

Method

- **Lemma co-occurrence scan** over the tagged Hebrew and Greek: a celestial lemma (3556 star, 8121 sun, 3394 moon, 4208 constellations, 4216 Mazzaroth, 4446 queen-of-heaven, 5522 Sakkuth, 3594 Kaiwan, or 6635+8064 "host of heaven") in the same verse as a cult lemma (7812 bow/worship, 5647 serve, 6999 burn incense, 5258 libation, 2076 sacrifice), followed by a second targeted pass.
- **Control:** Deuteronomy 4:19 confirmed present in output before the scan was trusted.
- **False positives reported rather than silently dropped** (Deut 16:6, Mal 1:11).

Secondary literature cited (Part II)

- **Gershom Scholem**, "The Curious History of the Six-Pointed Star: How the Magen David Became the Jewish Symbol," *Commentary* vol. 8, no. 3 (September 1949): 243-251. — Scholem's summary of a study he pursued for some fifty years, published shortly after the hexagram was adopted for the flag of Israel.
- **Gershom Scholem**, *Kabbalah* (1974), pp. 362-368. — Where the Sidon seal attestation is discussed.
- **Gershom Scholem**, "The Star of David: History of a Symbol," in *The Messianic Idea in Judaism and Other Essays on Jewish Spirituality* (1971).
- **Gerbern S. Oegema**, *The History of the Shield of David: The Birth of a Symbol*, Judentum und Umwelt / Realms of Judaism vol. 62 (Frankfurt am Main: Peter Lang, 1996), ISBN 3-631-30192-8. — Monograph tracing the hexagram from antiquity, where it was an ornamental and magical sign across many cultures, through the early Middle Ages to the twentieth century.
- **Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa**, *De occulta philosophia libri tres* (1533), Book II — planetary magic squares and their seals. **Saturn = 3×3 square.**
- **Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn**, hexagram ritual material (1888 onward) — hexagram as the generic figure of the seven planets.

⚠ **None of the Part II secondary literature was read in full for this document.** These are citations to the works where the claims are made, located and checked for accuracy of attribution — not a reading of the arguments in them. Anyone relying on Part II should go to Scholem 1949 and Oegema 1996 directly.

Sources NOT available, and what they would settle

- **Göttingen Septuagint** — copyrighted, not on disk. Would settle whether Greek Amos itself varied in the Rephan name. Its absence is why the LXX side here is closer to one witness than two.

- **Any LXX critical apparatus** — none on disk.
- **Secondary literature on ancient Near Eastern iconography** — the Assyrian rosette, Capernaum synagogue stone, and Prague flag claims in Part II rest on secondary sources not held here and are labelled accordingly.

Provenance standard applied

Texts are classified **ORIGINAL** (manuscript transcription) or **EDITED** (modern critical reconstruction). Rahlfs 1935 and Swete 1887–94 are both EDITED and both postdate the 1820 cut-off used in this project; the CNTR manuscript transcriptions are the ORIGINAL layer and are what check them. **Where the two conflict, the manuscripts are load-bearing.**

All English quotations are from the King James Version (public domain). Hebrew and Greek are quoted from the editions listed above. This document distinguishes throughout between what was verified against a primary text, what is unsettled within the data, and what is a secondary-literature claim.